



Positive and negative numbers

A POSITIVE NUMBER IS A NUMBER THAT IS MORE THAN ZERO, WHILE A NEGATIVE NUMBER IS LESS THAN ZERO.

A positive number is shown by a plus sign (+), or has no sign in front of it. If a number is negative, it has a minus sign (–) in front of it.

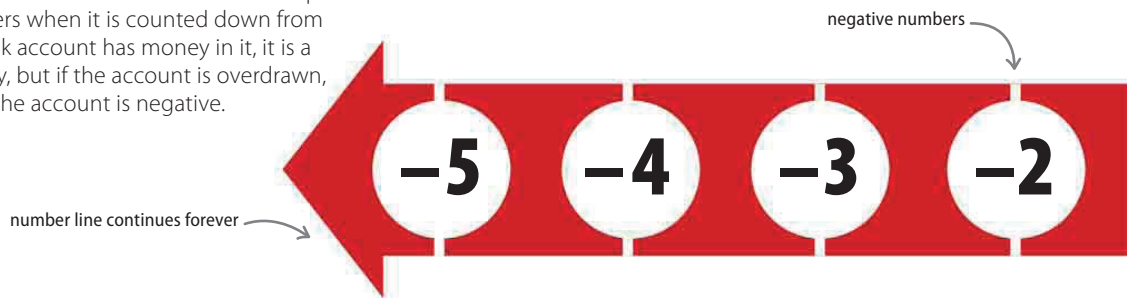
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◀ 14–15 Introducing numbers

◀ 16–17 Addition and subtraction

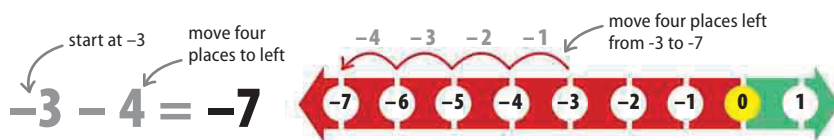
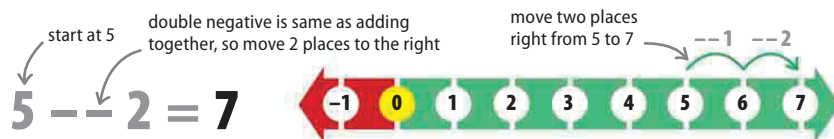
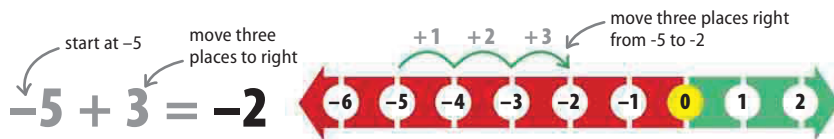
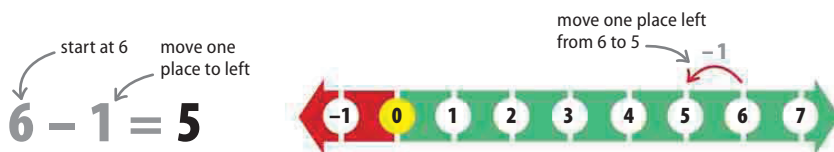
Why use positives and negatives?

Positive numbers are used when an amount is counted up from zero, and negative numbers when it is counted down from zero. For example, if a bank account has money in it, it is a positive amount of money, but if the account is overdrawn, the amount of money in the account is negative.



Adding and subtracting positives and negatives

Use a number line to add and subtract positive and negative numbers. Find the first number on the line and then move the number of steps shown by the second number. Move right for addition and left for subtraction.



LOOKING CLOSER

Double negatives

If a negative or minus number is subtracted from a positive number, it creates a double negative. The first negative is cancelled out by the second negative, so the result is always a positive, for example 5 minus –2 is the same as adding 2 to 5.

$$- \quad - \quad = \quad +$$

△ Like signs equal a positive

If any two like signs appear together, the result is always positive. The result is negative with two unlike signs together.